

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 15

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A recreational diver describes the afternoon she discovered a previously unknown underwater cave during a routine reef dive.

1

The reef I had dived a hundred times before was, that afternoon, behaving exactly as it always did. A school of fusiliers wheeled past in their usual silver hurry. A pair of clownfish bickered with their anemone. The sand sloped down to twenty metres and then, beyond that, into the comfortable blue darkness that I had long since stopped finding frightening. I was, in short, bored — and a bored diver is a curious diver, which is how I came to swim a little further along the wall than I usually did.

2

The entrance, when I first saw it, did not announce itself. It was a slit in the coral wall no wider than my shoulders, half hidden behind a curtain of orange sea fans. Most divers would have passed it without a second glance, and I nearly did. But something — a quality of the light, perhaps, or the lazy way the water seemed to **exhale** from the gap — made me hover. I checked my air. I checked my computer. Then I turned sideways and slipped, gently, through.

3

Inside, the world changed. The reef noises — the faint crackle of shrimp, the wash of the swell against rock — fell away to a hush so complete that I could hear my own heartbeat pressing against my eardrums. The passage widened. I switched on my torch, and the beam picked out a vaulted chamber, the size, perhaps, of a small chapel, its ceiling crusted with pale formations that hung like frozen drips of candle wax. I had read of such caves in geology textbooks. I had never imagined I might float, suspended, inside one.

4

For a few seconds my torch flickered. The chamber dimmed, brightened, dimmed again, and a familiar cold thing — panic — uncoiled in my chest. I forced myself to breathe slowly through the regulator, the way the instructors had drilled into us all those years ago. **In. Hold. Out.** The light steadied. So did I. I shone the beam upwards, then along the walls, and saw what I had not noticed before: the formations

were not random. They had grown, drop by patient drop, over what must have been thousands of years, in air pockets that had only later been swallowed by the sea.

5

What struck me, hovering there, was not the beauty alone, but the **untouchedness** of it. No diver's fin had stirred the silt on the floor. No careless hand had snapped one of the stone fingers from the ceiling. The chamber had been waiting, quite patiently, in the dark, while the world above it had invented telephones and aeroplanes and forgotten how to keep a secret. I felt, foolishly, like an intruder. I also felt, less foolishly, like the most fortunate person alive.

6

I stayed for perhaps eight minutes. I took no photographs. I touched nothing. When I turned to leave, I made myself move very slowly, so that my fins would not lift the fine silt and cloud the water for whoever — if anyone — came next. At the entrance I paused and looked back. The torch beam fell on the formations, and they seemed, for a moment, to be looking back at me. Then I slipped through the slit and was returned, gently, to the ordinary blue afternoon.

7

On the boat afterwards, the divemaster asked me whether I had seen anything interesting. The words **I found a cave** sat on my tongue like a small, bright coin. I swallowed them. "Nothing unusual," I said, and busied myself with my fins. He nodded, already turning to the next diver. I felt, briefly, the dishonesty of it — and then, with a clarity that surprised me, the rightness. A guidebook entry. A geotagged post. A queue of fins, churning the silt. Some places, I had decided in those eight quiet minutes, deserve to remain unfound.

8

I have been back to that reef many times since. I have never gone through the slit again. I think of the cave the way one thinks of a sleeping child — with affection, with care, and with the certainty that the kindest thing one can do is leave it undisturbed. The sea, after all, has kept far older secrets than mine. I am content to let it keep this one a little longer.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says "a bored diver is a curious diver." Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about why she swam further than usual that afternoon. [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show the reef felt familiar and unremarkable to the narrator. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator writes that the water seemed to "exhale" from the gap. Explain what this language suggests about the cave entrance. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator compares the chamber to "a small chapel." What does this comparison suggest about her feelings on first entering it? [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator describes panic as "a familiar cold thing" that "uncoiled in my chest."
- (a) What does the word **uncoiled** suggest about the way panic affects her? [1]
- (b) Give **one** detail from Paragraph 4 that shows she managed to control her panic. [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator says the chamber had been “waiting, quite patiently, in the dark, while the world above it had invented telephones and aeroplanes and forgotten how to keep a secret.” Explain how the language used in this paragraph creates a sense of **awe** and **contrast** between the cave and the outside world. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. Give **two** actions from Paragraph 6 that show the narrator was determined to leave the cave undisturbed. [2]

From Paragraph 7

8. The narrator writes that the words “I found a cave” sat on her tongue “like a small, bright coin.” What does this comparison suggest about the discovery? [2]

9. The narrator lists “A guidebook entry. A geotagged post. A queue of fins, churning the silt.” Why has the writer used **short, separate sentences** here? [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator compares the cave to “a sleeping child.” Explain what this comparison tells us about her attitude towards it now. [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the cultural costs of mass tourism.****1**

A generation ago, a holiday abroad was a rare and considered thing. Today, in the cities most prized by visitors, a holiday abroad is also, increasingly, a quiet act of disruption. In Venice, the resident population has fallen below fifty thousand for the first time in centuries, even as the city receives more than twenty million tourists a year. In Barcelona, locals have taken to spraying water pistols at diners on terraces. In Kyoto, signs in three languages now politely ask visitors not to chase geisha down the narrow lanes of Gion. The complaint is not new. What is new is its intensity, and the strange role that our phones have played in fuelling it.

2

The most visible cost is housing. Short-term rental platforms, which were sold to early users as a way for ordinary people to make a little extra income from a spare room, have in many cities become something quite different: a sprawling, semi-professional industry in which whole apartment blocks are stripped from the long-term rental market and converted into year-round lodging for tourists. The result, in Lisbon, Athens and Palma de Mallorca, has been a sharp rise in rents for the people who actually live there. A 2023 report by the European Commission found that rents in central Lisbon had risen by nearly 70 per cent over the previous decade, with short-term rentals named as one of the principal drivers.

3

There is also the slower, less visible cost: the loss of local identity. When a neighbourhood is reshaped to serve visitors rather than residents, its grocers become souvenir shops, its bakeries become “concept” cafes, and its laundries become luggage-storage offices. The shop signs change. The smells change. The languages overheard on the pavement change. A child who grows up in such a neighbourhood does not, strictly, lose her culture — but she may grow up surrounded by a costumed **performance** of her culture, sold back to her at tourist prices, while the real version retreats to suburbs that visitors do not photograph.

4

Social media has added a peculiar accelerant to this fire. A single viral video — a lavender field, a coloured staircase, a particular bend in a particular river — can, within weeks, draw such crowds to a previously quiet spot that local authorities are forced to install traffic lights, ticketing systems, or, in some cases, barriers. The Norwegian fjord village of Geiranger, with a year-round population of around two hundred, now greets cruise ships disgorging six thousand passengers in a single morning. The footprint of the visit is recorded, photographed, shared — and, within hours, sets the next wave of arrivals in motion. The site, in effect, becomes famous for being photographed.

5

Defenders of mass tourism point, fairly, to the jobs it creates and the foreign exchange it earns. Whole regions of Greece, Indonesia and the Caribbean depend, in the most literal sense, on visitors continuing to arrive. To wish tourism away is to wish away the livelihoods of the porters, cleaners, drivers, guides, cooks and stallholders who have built their working lives around it. Bali, where roughly half of the provincial economy is tied directly or indirectly to tourism, illustrates the dilemma painfully: the same visitors who clog the roads of Ubud also pay the school fees of the children of Ubud.

6

The most thoughtful response, then, is not to demonise the tourist but to redesign the visit. A growing number of cities have begun to experiment. Amsterdam has banned new hotels in its centre and capped river-cruise traffic. Venice now charges day-trippers a modest entry fee on peak days. Bhutan, more boldly, requires every foreign visitor to pay a daily “Sustainable Development Fee” of one hundred US

dollars, which is funnelled directly into schools, hospitals and forest conservation. The results are not yet conclusive, but the principle is clear: a visit should pay for the resources it consumes, including the less obvious ones — quietness, scarcity, dignity.

7

A natural objection is that such measures price out the less wealthy traveller. They do — and that, perhaps, is the uncomfortable point. For three decades, cheap flights and cheap rentals have allowed all of us to consume distant places as though they were endlessly renewable. They are not. If a city is, in the end, a fragile thing made of stones and people, then those of us who go to admire it might reasonably be asked to leave it, on departure, in roughly the state in which we found it — or, failing that, to pay for the difference.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that a holiday abroad has become “a quiet act of disruption.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the modern tourist. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** ways in which short-term rental platforms have changed since they were first introduced. [2]

14. The writer puts the words “**concept**” (in Paragraph 3) in **inverted commas**. What is the effect of this? [1]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says a child may grow up “surrounded by a costumed **performance** of her culture.” Explain what this tells us about how the writer feels about the change in such neighbourhoods. [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. The writer says social media has added “a peculiar accelerant to this fire.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this metaphor. [2]

17. The writer writes that a site can “become famous for being photographed.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says that “the same visitors who clog the roads of Ubud also pay the school fees of the children of Ubud.” Explain, in your own words, why the writer has set these two ideas side by side. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer says a visit should pay for “the less obvious” resources it consumes, including “quietness, scarcity, dignity.”

(a) Identify **one** resource in this list that is **not** normally thought of as something that can be “consumed.” [1]

(b) Explain why the writer chooses to describe these qualities as resources. [1]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer admits that higher fees will “price out the less wealthy traveller” and adds that “that, perhaps, is the uncomfortable point.” Explain what the writer means by calling this point **uncomfortable**. [2]

21. The writer ends by saying tourists should leave a city “in roughly the state in which we found it — or, failing that, to pay for the difference.” Explain how this sentence sums up the writer’s overall **argument**. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the cultural and social harms that mass tourism causes** and **the measures that cities and countries have begun to take in response**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Mass tourism has caused serious harm because ...

— END OF PAPER —